

Incident Alert 0012. TLP Clear.			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	Global - MATRYOSHKA: A pro-Russian campaign targeting media and the fact checking community		13/06/2024 2	

Summary

- This campaign is targeting media and fact-checking community with false content to debunk
- This campaign is spreading pro-Russian and anti-Ukraine narratives, as well as anti-France narratives
- This campaign is relying on different types of accounts on Telegram and X
- This campaign is active in more than 60 countries.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

Since late 2023, VIGINUM has observed and documented a malicious campaign that could affect French-speaking public debate online. This operation, dubbed “Matryoshka” in previous open sources reports, has been active since at least September 2023.

Its primary aim is to post fake content (reports, graffiti, memes, etc.), which is then shared in a coordinated manner on X (formerly Twitter), in the reply section of posts by the accounts of media outlets, public figures and fact-checking organizations in more than 60 countries. Matryoshka operators contact their targets directly on X and via email to ask them to investigate the fake content.

The fake content generally impersonates North American and European public figures and media outlets, including French ones. Although primarily anti-Ukrainian narratives are spread and amplified, this content also targets France’s Ukraine support policy, French politicians, and the Paris 2024 Olympic and Paralympic Games.

VIGINUM investigations have established that most of the content was first published on Russian-language Telegram channels, which had already been identified in information operations. VIGINUM considers that the aim of the Matryoshka campaign is most likely to discredit media outlets, public figures and fact-checking organizations targeted and to promote pro-Russia content.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Discrediting Western countries

Sub-narratives: The West will regret to support Ukraine

Sub-narratives: France is unable to host the Olympic Games

Impact

Reach: At this point, seeking an audience seems to be only a secondary goal for operators, as can be seen with the low audience volumes and weak engagement in campaign publications,⁴⁰ and despite the operating method being used against hundreds of entities.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: discredit media outlets, public figures and fact-checking organizations.

- [T0023.002] Edit Open-Source Content
- [T0099] Impersonate Existing Entity.
- [T0019] Generate Information Pollution

Recommendations

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
link	Media, Russia, Ukraine	See Annex of the report	VIGINUM	Article, meme, tweet, Photo, Video,	Telegram, Twitter